
Role of the teacher

The role of the teacher in transdisciplinary education is crucial and differs significantly from the traditional teaching role. This new role is not self-evident for everyone. It is important to actively discuss this beforehand and during the implementation. This page sheds light on the (changing) role of the teacher and the associated competencies.

As a teacher in transdisciplinary education, you play a crucial role. Among other things, you are:

- A facilitator of learning;**
- A mediator between academic disciplines and society;**
- A guide for students in developing competencies for understanding and addressing complex issues.**

There is still little known about the competencies associated with these teaching

roles. However, based on three articles, the following competencies appear important in transdisciplinary education (Veltman et al., 2022; Oonk et al., 2020; Flavian, 2024):

1
Flexibility and Adaptability

: You should be able to integrate various didactic methods and adapt to the learning needs of students.

2 Interdisciplinary understanding and subject expertise: it helps to have certain knowledge of multiple disciplines to make relevant connections and bring in innovative ideas.

3 Mediation and communication skills: you should be able to build and maintain relationships with external partners and facilitate collaboration between students and stakeholders.

4 Coaching and mentoring: it is your role to guide students in their development of transdisciplinary competencies.

5 Ongoing professional development: continuous professional development helps to keep up with new knowledge and didactic methods.

6 Balancing tensions
: you must help students navigate the tensions that arise when dealing with complex problems without disrupting the learning process.

Thus, the teacher can fulfil multiple roles in transdisciplinary education, often different from those in traditional education. It is important to monitor and discuss workload management. Not every teacher feels comfortable in this role, so it is essential to pay attention to this. The same applies to the professional development of a teacher in transdisciplinary education: there should be not only attention, but also time and space for it.

Here are insights from various transdisciplinary education teachers [Dutch video]: